



PAUL LEVINE &
HARRY PAPASOTIRIOU

AMERICA SINCE 1945

THE AMERICAN MOMENT



Introduction

Paul Levine

In February 1941, Henry Luce, the publisher of *Life* Magazine, wrote an editorial with the prophetic title 'The American Century'. Luce was one of those innovative entrepreneurs who shaped American life in the twentieth century. Like John D. Rockefeller, he combined the Protestant ethic and the spirit of Capitalism in his business magazine *Fortune*. Like William Randolph Hearst, he shaped modern journalism by inventing the weekly news magazine *Time*. And like Walt Disney he altered the way we see the world with *Life*, the famous magazine of photojournalism. Today, nearly forty years after Luce's death, his magazine empire has been transformed into a global 'infotainment' colossus that includes *Time* magazine, Warner Brothers movies, CNN television and the giant internet provider, AOL.

Like his legendary contemporaries, Henry Luce was an American patriot. But he was more of an internationalist than they were. Born in 1898 in China, Luce grew up with a strong sense of America's global mission. His parents were Protestant missionaries and he became the journalistic apostle of the American century. 'To him America was not just a country, it was an idea and an ideal,' says David Halberstam. 'His magazines would celebrate this.' Beginning in the 1920s, Luce sought to promote American values in his increasingly influential magazines. By midcentury, he had become the major media spokesman for the American Dream. 'He sought to make America what it should be and thus, of course, in the pages of *Time*, America *became* what it should be. The dream realized.'

In his 1941 editorial, 'The American Century', Luce urged his fellow countrymen to break with their traditional isolationism and lead the global fight against fascism. In World War I, the United States became a reluctant combatant after German submarines sank three American vessels. In 1919 a triumphant President Woodrow Wilson attended the Versailles Peace Conference with a sweeping plan to create a new world order; but he was thwarted by his French and British allies. After Wilson's failure, the US Congress rejected the peace treaty and refused to join the newly formed League of Nations that Wilson had proposed. After the outbreak of World War II in 1939, skeptical Americans were once again asked to come to the aid of their European allies. With France defeated and Britain beleaguered, the United States had become the last bulwark of Western democracy against Nazi Germany. Now, as citizens of the world's most powerful nation, Luce argued, Americans had an obligation to promote democratic principles throughout the world. Nine months later, the Japanese attacked Pearl Harbor and the United States embarked on a course of action that ultimately transformed modern times into what he called 'the American century'.



Times Square on VJ Day

Luce's editorial proved to be prophetic; but with some important reservations, as we shall see. Though the United States entered the conflict reluctantly only after the Japanese attack, Americans pursued the war enthusiastically. 'World War II was the most popular in American history,' notes the historian John Patrick Diggins. 'It was truly a people's war.' While Europe exhausted itself in a brutal conflict, the United States set out to create the most awesomely productive economic and military machine the world had ever seen. Moreover, American losses, though considerable, were slight in comparison to the devastation in Europe and Asia. The Americans suffered 400,000 deaths in battle whereas 35,000,000 Europeans – soldiers and civilians alike – died in just five years. 'In the years since Pearl Harbor the United States had overcome the greatest crisis facing the country since the Civil War,' says Diggins. 'A war that most Americans originally did not want to fight turned into one of the proudest triumphs in the history of the Republic.'

Thus at the end of World War II, the United States emerged as an economic, political and military superpower, a position it has held for more than half a century. As we entered a new millennium, Luce's idea of 'the American Century' took on a new currency. With the collapse of the Soviet Union, economic turmoil in Asia and political disunity in Europe, the United States remains by default the only global superpower. In the realm of culture, too, we have all experienced the long arm of American hyperpower. The world sees American films, hears American music, reads American books, copies American television programs and grumbles about the dangers of American cultural hegemony. The cultivation of efficient techniques of distribution has created mass culture and spread American values all over the world. Today critics speak anxiously of Globalization and Americanization as if they were the same thing.

We all recognize forms of 'American cultural imperialism', but what is American culture? For many skeptics, it is only McDonald's, Levi's and Hollywood. But a culture is more than a hamburger. When the Nobel Prize-winning novelist Saul Bellow was growing up in Chicago in the 1920s, the city was famous for its stockyards, steel mills, railroads and gangsters. 'What Chicago gave to the world was goods – a standard of living sufficient for millions. Bread, bacon, overalls, gas ranges, radio sets, telephone directories, false teeth, light bulbs, tractors, steel rails, gasoline,' Bellow writes. 'If you looked here for the sort of natural beauty described by Shakespeare, Milton, Wordsworth, Yeats, you would never find it.'

Yet, as the son of Russian Jewish immigrants, Bellow found something else in Chicago. As he recalled sixty years later:

The children of Chicago bakers, tailors, peddlers, insurance agents, pressers, cutters, grocers, the sons of families on relief, were reading buckram-bound books from the public library and were in a state of enthusiasm, having found themselves on the shore of a novelistic land to which they really belonged, discovering their birthright, hearing incredible news from the great world of culture, talking to one another about the mind, society, art, religion, epistemology, and doing this in Chicago, of all places.

But critics of American material culture are partly right. The historian William Leach describes how Americans created the modern world by combining corporate capitalism and consumer culture. 'In the decades following the Civil War, American capitalism began to produce a distinct culture, unconnected to traditional family or community values, to religion in any conventional sense, or to political democracy,' he says. The cardinal features of this culture were acquisition and consumption as a means of achieving happiness; the cult of the new; the democratization of desire; and money value as the predominant measure of all value in society.

Leach traces the evolution of the consumer society from its humble beginnings in retailing through its institutionalization in the consumer and service sectors, to its total acceptance as the American Way of Life. The flamboyant entrepreneurs of the late nineteenth century were transformed into anonymous corporations in the early twentieth century, comprising a network of department stores, investment bankers, advertising agencies, hotels, restaurants, movie theaters, model agencies, fashion groups and public relations firms. In creating a new culture of consumption, the modern captains of industry found unlikely partners in new institutions of higher learning like the Harvard Business School (founded in 1908) and high culture like the Metropolitan Museum of Art (its division of industrial design began in 1914). 'A new society has come to life in America,' noted a French observer in 1928. 'From a *moral point of view*, it is obvious that Americans have come to consider their standard of living as a somewhat sacred acquisition, which they will defend at any price.'

In redefining modern democracy as a mass consumer society, Americans followed a different path from the Europeans. The historian Olivier Zunz notes, 'As its size increased and its standard of living improved, the middle class became the hallmark of the "American century." In the "America-as-model" paradigm, the middle class, not the working class, is the revolutionary ideal. Promoting its values became the American alternative to Marxism.' Instead of the Marxist ideology of class conflict, Americans pointed to an expanding middle class society as the material expression of 'the American dream'. In the postwar years, this celebration of affluence became the hallmark of 'the American Way of Life' and the cornerstone of the ideology of 'the American Century'. Zunz concludes, 'In contrast to the situation in Europe, consumption, not welfare, was the American means of social cohesion.'

Of course, these achievements have had their costs, especially among those groups who were excluded from the American mainstream. But, despite its failures, the United States continues to pursue the prophesy of Henry Luce's 'American Century'. We know how American ideas about the organization of knowledge, the consumer society and multiculturalism have become part of the global cultural landscape as well. After the collapse of the Soviet empire in 1989, the French historian Francois Furet argued that while the Soviet Union had been a superpower, it had never been a civilization. The proof was that it could vanish without leaving any substantial legacy behind. But the opposite is true of the United States. The idea of 'the American Century' became the basis for the establishment of the 'Pax Americana'. Unlike the

Soviet Union, says Zunz, 'The United States became a superpower precisely because of its civilization.'

This book is an exploration of American civilization in the period between World War II and the present. If this does not constitute an American Century, it can be seen as the American Moment: the time when, for good or ill, the United States became the predominant political, military, economic and cultural power in the world. In this book, we wish to examine the American Moment in a global context. Our approach is both interdisciplinary and dialogic. By using elements of political science and international relations, media and cultural studies, and social, intellectual and literary history, we try to present a multidimensional picture of the United States in its relation to the larger world. The odd-numbered chapters are written by a political scientist, Harry Papasotiriou; they move chronologically through major events in international relations and American domestic politics. The even-numbered chapters are written by a literary historian, Paul Levine; they explore thematically the central developments in American culture and society. By structuring our book in alternating chapters emphasizing political and cultural developments respectively, we hope to establish a dialogue between the authors and with the reader.

The two authors come from different cultural backgrounds but share similar intellectual interests. Harry Papasotiriou is Greek. He was born in Frankfurt, Germany, in 1961 and grew up in Athens, Greece. He was educated in England and the United States, earning a BA in Philosophy, Politics and Economics from the University of Oxford (1983) and an MA and PhD from Stanford University (1992). Since 1992 he has been a senior fellow of the Institute for International Relations at Panteion University; since 1998 he has taught in Panteion's Department of International Relations, where he holds the rank of Associate Professor.

Paul Levine is American. Born in Brooklyn, New York, in 1936, he studied English Literature and Art History at Wesleyan University (BA, 1958), American Literature and Intellectual History at Princeton University, and received his PhD in the History of American Civilization from Harvard University (1973). Afterwards he taught at Wesleyan and the University of Rochester and in Canada at York University. Since 1975 he has been Professor of American Literature at Copenhagen University. He has also been a visiting professor in American Studies in Budapest, Hungary, and Shanghai, China.

In 1994 Levine became the director of the Athens American Studies Seminar. Over the past decade he and Papasotiriou have collaborated on this annual interdisciplinary symposium where American, Greek and other European academics, students and professionals meet to explore a variety of complex issues ranging from the legacy of the Cold War to the crisis of Globalization. As we studied problems ranging from the rule of international law to the role of global media, we became aware of the need for a new kind of textbook to introduce students and general readers to the issues facing the United States and the world. Over the past four years we have worked together in formulating a new approach, drawing on recently released archives in international relations and the latest research in social science and the humanities. The text that follows is the fruit of this collaboration.

RECOMMENDED READING

Saul Bellow, *It All Adds Up*, New York: Viking, 1994.

John Patrick Diggins, *The Proud Decades*, New York: Norton, 1988.

David Halberstam, *The Powers That Be*, New York: Knopf, 1979.

Godfrey Hodgson, *America in Our Time*, New York: Doubleday, 1976.

William Leach, *Land of Desire*, New York: Pantheon, 1993.

Olivier Zunz, *Why the American Century?* Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1993.

American Politics from Roosevelt to Truman

Alexis de Tocqueville in 1835 gazed into the future of the United States and Russia and declared that each 'seems marked by the will of Heaven to sway the destinies of half the globe'. His famous prediction came true a little over one century later. Yet the rise of these two world powers could scarcely have been more contrasted. Russia rose after centuries of intense and often bloody competition in the merciless arena of European Great Power politics. The United States was insulated from Europe's intense political competition by the world's largest oceans; instead it massively expanded its territory from the original thirteen states to a continental-sized federation against the weak opposition of the Mexicans and the Native Americans. More Americans were killed in the Civil War of 1861–5 than in any other war in American history. The origin of America's ascendancy in world politics is its phenomenal industrialization in the later nineteenth century, which transformed a nation of farmers, craftsmen and traders into the world's most formidable industrial power. By the end of the nineteenth century the American economy was the largest in the world, has remained so ever since, and is likely to remain so well into the twenty-first century.

Yet the rise of the United States to the top of world politics came just after the Great Depression, the worst economic disaster in American history. In the 1930s America was economically prostrate, diplomatically isolated and militarily weak. Then came World War II, during which the United States emerged as the leading power of our times. The experiences of Depression and world war were so profound, and the United States so transformed by them, that in American parlance the 'modern' begins with this period. The first modern president was Franklin Roosevelt, the master politician and statesman who dominated American politics during those momentous years of crisis and transformation. His successor Harry Truman seemed inadequate at first to follow in Roosevelt's footsteps, but he soon proved his worth as one of America's greatest modern leaders, laying the foundations of America's postwar engagement in world politics.

The legacy of Franklin Roosevelt in American politics

American postwar politics were shaped by the massive realignment that took place in the 1930s. Before the Great Depression, the Republicans had dominated for seventy years, in which only two Democrats had been elected to the presidency (Grover Cleveland and Woodrow Wilson). The Republican Party was a

very broad coalition that included conservatives and progressives, industrialists and labor unions, blacks and whites, internationalists and isolationists. A party that had dominated for so long, and that had become especially identified with industrialization and business prosperity, was bound to be held responsible for the Great Depression and to lose the support of the voters. The economic decline during Herbert Hoover's presidency in 1929–33 was almost unimaginably steep. Gross domestic product (GDP) in 1933 was half that of 1929. Agricultural income had declined by two-thirds. Unemployment rose to 25 per cent. Under these circumstances, the Democrats were bound to win the election of 1932.

The Democratic standard bearer who led his party to victory in 1932 was Franklin Delano Roosevelt (FDR), a patrician from up-state New York. Roosevelt became one of the greatest presidents in American history, comparable only to Washington and Lincoln. Yet his earlier career gave few clues to his later mastery. His first steps in politics replicated exactly the career of his distant cousin, President Theodore Roosevelt (1901–9), except that FDR seemed like an inferior copy. His character became less frivolous and gained depth after 1921, when he was struck by poliomyelitis that paralyzed his legs. With enormous will power he persevered in politics, placing himself at the front rank of the Democratic Party by winning the governorship of New York in 1928, a year in which the Democrats did badly otherwise. Justice Oliver Wendell Holmes shrewdly assessed FDR's qualities: 'A second-class intellect. But a first-class temperament!' Roosevelt proved to be a charismatic leader who reassured and inspired Americans in the depths of the Depression and during the mighty challenges of World War II; an open-minded reformer willing to experiment with new remedies for unprecedented problems; a skillful though often devious manager who dominated his government and his party, securing its presidential nomination four times; and in his last years a world leader who in wartime policy and strategy compares well with Old World giants like Winston Churchill and Joseph Stalin.

FDR's New Deal laid the foundations of the American welfare state and created new machinery for federal engagement in the economy and society, while working within and in effect improving the existing capitalist system. Among its greatest and most lasting achievements are Social Security, which provides old-age pensions; the Securities Exchange Commission (SEC) and the Federal Bank Deposit Insurance Corporation (FDIC), which regulate and stabilize financial markets; the Fair Labor Standards Act and the National Labor Relations Board, which regulate the labor market; and a federal willingness to finance infrastructure development in the states. The New Deal did not substantially change the income distribution in the United States, nor did it engage in nationalization of production – with the exception of the Tennessee Valley Authority (TVA), a federal agency that helped develop a desperately poor region stretching across seven Southern states. As the historian David Kennedy has argued in *Freedom from Fear*, the New Deal was about security:

security for vulnerable individuals, . . . for capitalists and consumers, for workers and employers, for corporations and farms and homeowners and bankers and builders as well. Job security, life-cycle security, financial security, market

security – however it might be defined, achieving security was the leitmotif of virtually everything the New Deal attempted.¹

What was the New Deal coalition?

Franklin Roosevelt shaped postwar American politics because he succeeded in transforming what might have been only a temporary Democratic victory in 1932 into a lasting party realignment. His New Deal coalition dominated American politics until 1968. Its central elements will become visible by an examination of the main cleavages in American society in the middle of the twentieth century.

- *North versus South.* This cleavage anteceded America's independence and led to the Civil War of 1861–5, which broke out when the anti-slavery Republicans won the national elections for the first time in 1860, resulting in the secession of the South. For one century after the Civil War, the South was solidly Democratic. The borderline state of Tennessee, which was split during the Civil War, remained split almost exactly along the same lines until the 1960s, with almost all counties that had sent their men to the Union army voting Republican and those that had fought with the Confederacy voting Democratic. The Solid South was thus one of the most important elements of the New Deal coalition.
- *Creditors versus debtors.* This cleavage pitted farmers and small-scale businessmen, especially in the South, the West and the agricultural Midwest, against the great but much despised financial centers of New York and Chicago. The Democrats had aligned themselves with the debtors against the bankers since the nineteenth century. The Midwesterner Harry Truman (Missouri) was a typical representative of this tradition in mid-twentieth century. On his way to France during World War I, he passed through New York and expressed only contempt for this glittering metropolis (by contrast, he loved Paris). In the early 1920s, he and one of his fellow war veterans opened a haberdashery that went bankrupt because the start-up loans could not be repaid. In politics, he was most effective as a tribune of the common people against the 'Wall Street Republicans'. In this tradition, the New Deal did much to support defaulting homeowners and farmers who faced foreclosures.
- *Employers versus labor.* One of the most significant and lasting changes brought about by the New Deal was the conversion of the labor unions from Republicans to Democrats. The New Deal's Wagner Act, which protected the right of collective bargaining, constituted the most important pro-labor legislation in American history, and transformed the unions virtually into components of the Democratic Party.
- *Rural versus urban.* Before the Great Depression the Democrats were largely a party of the rural South and West, and the Republicans were mostly the party of the industrial Northeast and Midwest. The New Deal altered this alignment and made the Democrats dominant in the cities. In his 1936 re-election, Roosevelt won 102 out of the 104 cities in the United States with a population over 100,000. The subsequent Democratic domination in urban America

brought great power and influence to the urban party bosses who ran the largely corrupt patronage machines.

It should be noted that FDR entered politics as an anti-machine reformer, following in the footsteps of his illustrious predecessor, Theodore Roosevelt. But as president he needed the cooperation of the urban machine bosses to win elections. His successor Harry Truman was a product of the Kansas City machine run by Tom Pendergast, who was one of the most powerful political bosses in the country until his downfall and imprisonment for corruption in 1939. (There was no taint of corruption regarding Truman.)

- *WASPs versus newer immigrants and blacks.* In 1940, out of 140 million Americans, 11.5 million had been born abroad, 23 million had parents born abroad, and 22 million spoke English as a second language. These new immigrant groups were concentrated mainly in the cities of the Northeast and the industrial Midwest. They lived largely in ethnic neighborhoods, in which they preserved some of the traditions of their old countries. Being underdogs in American society, they overwhelmingly supported the New Deal and became a key factor in Democratic electoral politics for decades thereafter. The homogenizing pressures of total warfare facilitated the decline of the ethnic neighborhoods after World War II, but the postwar allegiance of ethnic Americans to the Democratic Party was lasting. At the same time, the New Deal also produced a change in the allegiance of African Americans from the Republicans to the Democrats. After they abandoned the party of Abraham Lincoln, the blacks in time became the most solidly Democratic group in the United States. This fact, though, could not easily be reconciled with the presence of the racist Solid South in the Democratic Party.

Roosevelt led this great New Deal coalition in the direction of federal activism for the cure of the ills in American society, which has become the defining attitude of American liberalism ever since. Yet the New Deal coalition was a very broad church that spanned the mainstream American ideological spectrum, much like the ruling Republican coalition that preceded it. The Solid South, in particular, was essentially conservative and from 1938 onwards acted as a brake to further liberal initiatives by the federal government.

The ability of Southern Democrats to impede liberal activism by the federal government derived from their disproportionate power in Congress, in which the powerful committee chairs were apportioned strictly by seniority within the majority party. Before the 1930s the Democrats were very much the minority party; thus a large portion of the new Democratic congressional majorities in the 1930s and 1940s consisted of representatives and senators with little seniority. Not so those from the Solid South, which had hardly ever elected a Republican to Congress (except during Reconstruction). As a result, the small oligarchies of about two dozen committee chairmen that dominated the House and the Senate were disproportionately from the South.

If postwar liberal activism faced constraints from the conservative elements of the New Deal coalition, it was assisted by a major and lasting expansion in the size of the federal revenue base during World War II. The size of the federal government during the Roosevelt presidency increased less during the New Deal reforms

Table 1 Income tax in the United States, 1940–60²

Year	Lowest bracket income tax, percentage	Lowest bracket income, in \$	Highest bracket income tax, percentage	Highest bracket income, in \$	Millions paying income tax
1940	4.4	4,000	81.1	5,000,000	14.7
1941	10.0	2,000	81.0	5,000,000	25.9
1942	19.0	2,000	88.0	200,000	36.6
1943	19.0	2,000	88.0	200,000	43.7
1944	23.0	2,000	94.0	200,000	47.1
1945	23.0	2,000	94.0	200,000	49.9
1946	19.0	2,000	86.5	200,000	52.8
1950	17.4	2,000	84.4	200,000	53.1
1960	20.0	2,000	91.0	200,000	61.0

than under the pressures of the war. The expanding federal government was paid for by higher income taxes. At the highest brackets the New Deal had raised the income tax to 81.1 per cent, but this applied only to the small number of the truly rich with incomes over \$5 million. In 1942 the highest-bracket income tax was raised to 88 per cent. Much more significant, though, was the lowering of the definition of the highest bracket to incomes over \$200,000, vastly expanding the number of people who fell into this bracket.

Similarly, at the lowest end the income tax was raised from 4.4 per cent in 1940 to 23 per cent in 1944. At least as important, though, was the lowering of the definition of the lowest bracket from incomes of \$4000 in 1940 to \$2000 in 1941, which meant that several million Americans were taxed for the first time. The economic boom that began in the 1940s continually added more people to the income groups subject to income tax. The resultant rapid rise in the number of people that paid income taxes is shown in the last column of Table 1.

The rise in income taxes during the war was by and large not reversed after 1945, providing the postwar federal government with a large stream of revenue that made possible not only new domestic programs but also international initiatives like the Truman Doctrine and the Marshall Plan. During World War II, the federal government acquired the revenue base that enabled the United States to move from the periphery to the center of world politics.

American society in the 1940s

In the mid-1940s the United States produced half the industrial product of the world. American per capita income was about double that of the group of next richest countries: Canada, Great Britain, New Zealand, Switzerland and Sweden. Nonetheless, many Americans still lived in surprisingly primitive conditions. In 1947 one-third of American households had no running water, two-fifths had no flush toilets and three-fifths had no central heating. Moreover, in spite of massive industrialization and the attendant urbanization, a majority of Americans still lived in towns with less than 10,000 inhabitants. About 17.5 per cent of the population still depended on agriculture for a living. Over 30 per cent of the

population was under the official poverty line, in spite of the wartime economic recovery that ended the Great Depression, with black and Mexican-American agricultural laborers at the bottom of the wage ladder.

The American economy in the 1940s displayed far greater regional variations in income levels than today. The South in particular was much less developed than the rest of the United States, constituting a kind of 'third world' within the world's richest economy. Southern economic backwardness was somewhat alleviated by the New Deal's ambitious infrastructure projects such as the TVA that provided electricity and paved roads in much of the region. Still, the South did not catch up with the rest of the United States until the last quarter of the twentieth century.

Internal migrations reveal some of the dynamics in American society in the early postwar period. Throughout American history one major internal migration stream has been from East to West, with people moving from the densely populated Eastern seaboard to the vast expanses of the heartland and the West. This population movement gradually changed the political and electoral balances in the United States. In 1940 New York's population towered above that of any other state. Next in population were Pennsylvania, Illinois, Ohio and California. By 1950 California had jumped into second place, narrowly overtaking Pennsylvania though still far behind New York. Today California has about twice the population of the next state, which is Texas, while New York has fallen to third place. Richard Nixon's meteoric rise – he was elected vice-president in 1952 just before his fortieth birthday – reflected California's growing importance in American politics.

A second migration stream moved from the underdeveloped South to the industrial centers of the North and the West. This interregional population movement largely amounted to a labor movement from the agricultural to the industrial sector of the American economy. With the end of the Great Depression, the American economy entered a long period of high growth that lasted, with but brief interruptions, from the 1940s through the 1960s. This prolonged economic boom marginalized the agricultural sector, pulling many people from the still largely agricultural South to more developed areas of the country.

A part of the postwar emigration from the South consisted of African Americans, who had more than economic reasons to migrate. At the end of the nineteenth century and the beginning of the twentieth, Southern states instituted a system of racial segregation that separated blacks and whites in schools, churches, parks, restaurants, hotels, public transport and other public facilities. Moreover, Southern authorities resorted to unconstitutional devices to disenfranchise virtually all blacks in the South, as well as to exclude them from juries in violation of common law rights that went back to the medieval England of Henry II. In addition to these forms of official racial discrimination, blacks often suffered from the violent racism of many Southern whites – 138 were lynched in the period 1930–45 – while the exclusively white judges and juries in Southern courts were hardly unbiased in trials concerning blacks.

The black exodus from the South had begun before 1945, but it accelerated in the early postwar period. Whereas at the beginning of the twentieth century almost all African Americans lived in the South, by 1970 only 53 per cent did.

The acceleration of black emigration was related to the fact that one million African Americans served in the armed forces during World War II. Having risked life and limb for their nation fighting against Hitler's racism, many were unwilling thereafter to tolerate racism at home. As one black corporal put it, 'I spent four years in the Army to free a bunch of Dutchmen and Frenchmen, and I'll be hanged if I am going to let the Alabama version of the Germans kick me around when I get home.'³ The economic boom of the 1940s facilitated the black exodus from the South. For example, a Southern black maid who worked for \$3.50 a week moved to California during the war and found work in an armaments plant for \$48 a week.

The black migration to the North and the West did not result in greater racial integration, producing the greatest tragedy of postwar American society. As blacks poured into the poorer neighborhoods of the Northern and Western cities, whites started moving out. Without sanction or design by the authorities, substantial racial segregation resulted from the behavior of individuals, as if water and oil had been mixed and then separated. This metaphor is not exact, since racially mixed areas have existed in the Northern and Western cities throughout the postwar era. Yet segregated neighborhoods did emerge at the lower and the higher ends of the socio-economic scale.

At the bottom, the result was the creation of black urban ghettos, mostly a postwar phenomenon, which in time had explosive consequences for American society and politics. The decline of America's inner cities resulted from a vicious circle in which the flight of whites after the arrival of blacks led to shrinking local employment opportunities, resulting in disproportionately high unemployment rates in the black ghettos. Over time, a significant portion of the ghettos' unskilled blacks found themselves isolated from the surrounding job markets.

At the top, the result was all-white suburbs that expanded rapidly after the war and absorbed an ever-growing portion of America's middle class. The rapid growth of the suburbs resulted from the economic boom in conjunction with two federal programs. Highway construction enabled the daily commute from home in the suburbs to work in the city that has become a prominent neo-nomadic feature of life in the modern world. The GI Bill of Rights of 1944 provided generous housing benefits to the veterans of World War II, about 13 per cent of the population, many of whom were thus able to buy new houses in the suburbs.

In some suburbs African Americans were excluded not only by lack of income. Suburban developers often devised contracts that prohibited the sale or renting of housing units to blacks, in order to protect the value of their investments, since the entry of blacks into a suburban neighborhood could lead to a collapse in real estate values. Such private contracts tended to be honored in practice even after the US Supreme Court declared them unconstitutional and unenforceable in the courts.

The emerging black ghettos were like a wound in the American polity that festered slowly. In the 1940s the wound was still minor. For the vast majority of Americans this decade brought unparalleled prosperity and upward mobility. The awful ruins of the Great Depression receded in the background and faded from the view of a society that optimistically sped forward toward unprecedented material progress and wealth.

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The black exodus from the South had begun before 1945, but it accelerated in the early postwar period. Whereas at the beginning of the twentieth century almost all African Americans lived in the South, by 1970 only 53 per cent did.

The acceleration of black emigration was related to the fact that one million African Americans served in the armed forces during World War II. Having risked life and limb for their nation fighting against Hitler's racism, many were unwilling thereafter to tolerate racism at home. As one black corporal put it, 'I spent four years in the Army to free a bunch of Dutchmen and Frenchmen, and I'll be hanged if I am going to let the Alabama version of the Germans kick me around when I get home.'³ The economic boom of the 1940s facilitated the black exodus from the South. For example, a Southern black maid who worked for \$3.50 a week moved to California during the war and found work in an armaments plant for \$48 a week.

The black migration to the North and the West did not result in greater racial integration, producing the greatest tragedy of postwar American society. As blacks poured into the poorer neighborhoods of the Northern and Western cities, whites started moving out. Without sanction or design by the authorities, substantial racial segregation resulted from the behavior of individuals, as if water and oil had been mixed and then separated. This metaphor is not exact, since racially mixed areas have existed in the Northern and Western cities throughout the postwar era. Yet segregated neighborhoods did emerge at the lower and the higher ends of the socio-economic scale.

At the bottom, the result was the creation of black urban ghettos, mostly a postwar phenomenon, which in time had explosive consequences for American society and politics. The decline of America's inner cities resulted from a vicious circle in which the flight of whites after the arrival of blacks led to shrinking local employment opportunities, resulting in disproportionately high unemployment rates in the black ghettos. Over time, a significant portion of the ghettos' unskilled blacks found themselves isolated from the surrounding job markets.

At the top, the result was all-white suburbs that expanded rapidly after the war and absorbed an ever-growing portion of America's middle class. The rapid growth of the suburbs resulted from the economic boom in conjunction with two federal programs. Highway construction enabled the daily commute from home in the suburbs to work in the city that has become a prominent neo-nomadic feature of life in the modern world. The GI Bill of Rights of 1944 provided generous housing benefits to the veterans of World War II, about 13 per cent of the population, many of whom were thus able to buy new houses in the suburbs.

In some suburbs African Americans were excluded not only by lack of income. Suburban developers often devised contracts that prohibited the sale or renting of housing units to blacks, in order to protect the value of their investments, since the entry of blacks into a suburban neighborhood could lead to a collapse in real estate values. Such private contracts tended to be honored in practice even after the US Supreme Court declared them unconstitutional and unenforceable in the courts.

The emerging black ghettos were like a wound in the American polity that festered slowly. In the 1940s the wound was still minor. For the vast majority of Americans this decade brought unparalleled prosperity and upward mobility. The awful ruins of the Great Depression receded in the background and faded from the view of a society that optimistically sped forward toward unprecedented material progress and wealth.